



Navigating Intercultural Communication in the Media Landscape: Challenging Stereotypes and Cultivating Critical Perspectives—Hall Model as the Framework

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Abstract

This brief commentary delves into the intricate dynamics of intercultural communication within the realm of media influence, emphasising the importance of critical analysis and resistance to stereotypes. Drawing on Stuart Hall’s encoding-decoding model, the essay explores how audiences engage with media narratives from multiple perspectives, including dominant, negotiated, and oppositional readings. By examining two news through Hall’s model, the analysis reveals how audiences challenge prevailing stereotypes and biases, promoting a more nuanced understanding of complex social issues. The commentary highlights the role of the media in shaping identity dynamics and underscores the significance of audience agency in interpreting and responding to media messages. Through a nuanced analysis of media content, this essay contributes to a deeper understanding of the intricate interplay between media representations, audience perceptions, and cultural identities in the contemporary communication landscape.

Keywords Intercultural communication · Media landscape · Critical perspectives · Hall model

The media is an important tool for information dissemination because it shapes people’s view of the world, impacts their cognition, and develops the concepts of individuals, groups, and society as a whole (Viswanath et al., 2007). In the twenty-first century, new media forms have profoundly changed communication methods used within intercultural communication, such as due to the impact of the internet, mobile phones, social media, and virtual reality, which have all strengthened the connection between individuals and diverse cultural groups (Shuter, 2012). This, however,

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is not without potential issues, as the media's dissemination of information can be biased or present a view that lacks objectivity and neutrality; it sometimes presents stereotypes and negative images in the context of multiculturalism and identity (Appel & Weber, 2021; Seiter, 1986). This leads to a negative impact on people's self-cognition, as well as on the identity and cultural exchange of different social groups (Tomin et al., 2016). Despite this, audiences are not in a powerless state when they receive media information, something that Hall's (1973, 1980) 'encoding' and 'decoding' models consider. This model emphasises that audiences understand information based on their cultural experience and background, thus meaning that audiences can resist negative media images (Hall, 1980). Based on Hall's (1980) model, this paper seeks to explore how media shapes identity, and how audiences can deal with any negative effects as the result of potential stereotypes in the media.

1 Conceptual Framework

"Critical Intercultural Communication" refers to the examination of communication across cultural boundaries through a critical lens, emphasising the deconstruction of power dynamics, social inequalities, and cultural stereotypes to promote understanding and inclusivity (Ferri, 2018). Hall's (1980) encoding/decoding model provides a valuable framework for understanding how communication across cultural boundaries operates, aligning with the principles of critical intercultural communication (Halualani et al., 2009; Kropp, 2015). By integrating Hall's model into the discussion, it allows for a deeper exploration of the complexities involved in intercultural communication dynamics. This facilitates the promotion of understanding and inclusivity across diverse cultural contexts (Germain-Rutherford & Barbara, 2008).

2 Hall's Encoding/Decoding Model

In Hall's 1973 paper titled 'Encoding and Decoding in Television Discourse', a theoretical model of media transmission and meaning was proposed (Shaw, 2017). Later, Hall (1980) further developed this model, which combines the power of the media as an ideological medium and recognises the power of viewers to resist media ideological messages. Such researchers as Katz (2003) have stated that Hall's (1980) paper is one of the 'classic texts of media studies', and McQuail (2010) has explained that this model is one of four recognised models of mass communication, with the other three being the transmission model, the ritual model, and the publicity model. Returning to Hall's model, the 'encoding' element means that the person sharing the information converts the transmitted information, meaning, intention, or viewpoint into a symbolic code or information with specific rules so that it is easy to understand and translate through verbal or non-verbal forms (Hall, 1973; Zhao, 2014). On the other hand, 'decoding' represents the process by which the recipient of a message interprets it and/or recreates the conveyed ideology (Xie et al., 2022). The process between encoding and decoding can be seen below, in Fig. 1. This model encompasses both the production process of encoding meaning into text form, as well as the complex

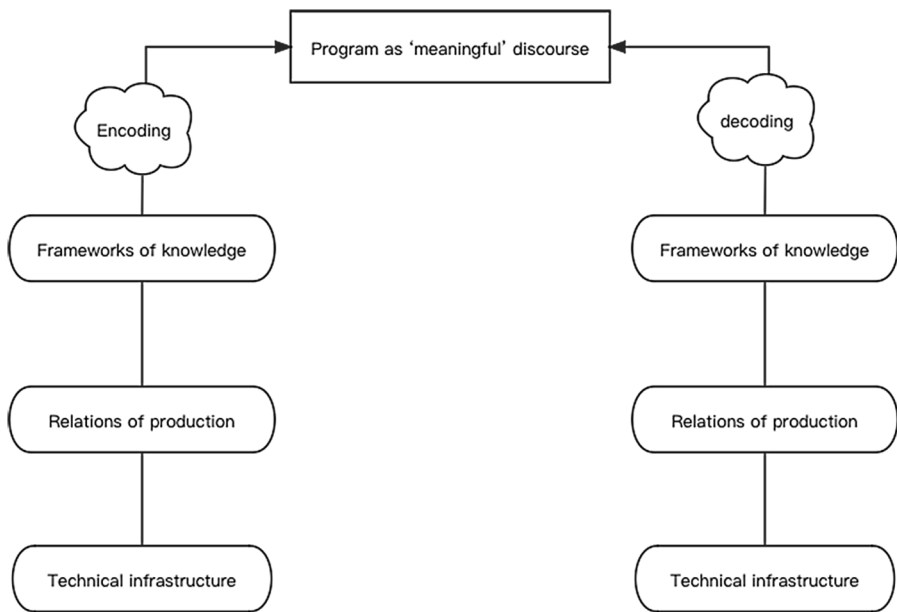


Fig. 1 Hall's encoding/decoding model (Hall, 1980, p. 130)

process of decoding information; this can lead to some complex results due to audiences' diverse reading comprehension levels (Yousman, 2013).

McQuail (2010) went on to explain that the most important feature of Hall's (1980) model is that there can be no assumption about the meaning of encoding and decoding or how they should correspond. This is because any interpretation is dependent on the knowledge framework or code that encodes the program, i.e., the audience's conceptual system (McQuail, 2010). Hall (1980, p. 134) explains that there is a pattern of "preferred reading", and that this is based on readers' own institutional, political, or ideological interpretations. However Morley (1981) considered whether 'preferred reading' is the result of the meaning inherent in the text, the reading of the analyst, or the reading of the majority. Indeed, while some writers (e.g. Pillai, 1992; Shaw, 2017; Wren-Lewis, 1983) have also considered the concept of 'preferred reading' Hall (1994) clearly shared the view that it is a textual attribute:

...preferred reading is simply a way of saying if you have control of the apparatus of signifying the world if you're in control of the media, you own it you write the texts — to some extent it has a determining shape. Your decodings are going to take place somewhere within the universe of encoding. (Hall, 1994, p. 261).

As Hall (1994) demonstrates, there is a fusion between the dominant ideology and the sender's encoding intentions and practices; hence, meaning is not fixed because it is strongly influenced by encoding, however, it is also not completely controlled (Shaw, 2017). With further regard to decoding, Hall (1980) shares three ways that an audi-

ence may receive information, which is firstly full acceptance of the encoded information (dominant reading); secondly, global acceptance of the information while rejecting any particular information (negotiated reading); and thirdly, total rejection of the information (oppositional interpretation). This shows that an audience uses their subjective initiative and independent thinking when receiving information, even when the image presented is negative. Here, the audience can offset the negative impact through their ability to decode.

As has been demonstrated above, Hall's (1980) model focuses on individuals in mass communication; it recognises and respects audiences' intelligence and abilities, accepts that there exists a broad range of meanings within media texts, and seeks to gather a deeper understanding of how people interpret media content. These elements can all be used to provide insight into the daily use of media in social contexts (Aligwe et al., 2018; Kropp, 2015; Xie et al., 2022). However, Hall's (1980) model is not without limitations, and some of these are theoretical, meaning that although it focuses on the decoding competence and diversity of the audience, it may be too idealistic. In this way, Hall (1994) acknowledges that the original thinking behind the model is inherently controversial, and thus, may be considered to be an oversimplified linear communication model that is the basis of communication research (Colombo, 2004; McQuail, 2013). As such, Hall's (1980) model may overlook the complexity of meaning, assuming that the message receiver can perfectly understand the sender's intent. Furthermore Aligwe et al. (2018) state that Hall's (1980) model provides inadequate explanations for the differences in an audience's understanding of the same media content, especially in different cultural contexts.

A further limitation or criticism of the model is that it potentially overlooks actual media influence. To begin Zhao (2014) and Wang (2017) explain that the model emphasises audiences' initiative and the potentially diverse interpretation of media information; however, this could lead to the underestimation of the media's influence (Davison, 1983; Silverblatt et al., 2014). In this way, the emphasis on audience agency may overshadow or underestimate the significant influence that the media exerts on shaping perceptions and social attitudes. This is especially true for groups who may be more easily influenced by the media, or for those in a socially disadvantaged position; these groups may be more inclined to then form stereotypes and negative images of 'other' groups (Taylor, 2015). Hall (1994) and Grossberg (2006) both considered this, stating that the media can promote or even establish stereotypes as the result of systematic bias in the description of social systems. Morley (Morley, 2006, p. 111) also touched on this, stating that "All of this is to suggest that there are serious problems still to be resolved in developing the original insights generated by the encoding/decoding model—but it is also to recognise that the model, despite its limitations, still has much to offer." Therefore, some limitations do exist when considering Hall's (1980) model, yet it maintains an important perspective and theoretical framework when exploring the media's influence on identity. To explore this aspect, the following section considers 'identity' and aims to discover how the media can affect both individual and group identity, and in this realm, how the audience plays an integral role.

3 The Media's Role in Identity Dynamics and Intercultural Impressions

Delahunty (2013) explains that the identity dynamic is a complex and multi-layered concept that involves the process of forming and maintaining self-cognition in different social situations. In line with this Van Nes (2012) dissects the different components of identity, arguing that there are six key components: logo, colour, typography, graphic elements, imagery, and language. Van Nes' (2012) view of identity does not only consider an individual's internal cognition, but also recognises that it encompasses an external visual and perceptual feature that has been developed through the use of visual and linguistic elements.

The media plays an important and powerful role in shaping and influencing individual identity (Grossberg, 2006; Nakamura, 2005). When juxtaposed with Van Nes' (2012) perspective on visual elements in the media, it becomes evident that media portrayal significantly influences people's self-perception and their perceptions of others. For instance Liu and Zhang (2020) mentioned that exploring Americans' perceptions of targeted Chinese people on Facebook found a troubling trend: the perpetuation and reinforcement of stereotypes through the pervasive spread of media on these platforms through a meticulous analysis of user interactions, comments, and shared content. Liu and Zhang (2020) demonstrated the interplay between an information source and its content in identity dynamics, showing that people's perceptions of a group of people are influenced within an online intercultural context.

In studies that consider group identity dynamics, it has been found that individuals play an important role in shaping and maintaining the impression of group identity (Montgomery & Zhang, 2018; Ruble & Zhang, 2012). For instance, during interactions, individuals may adjust their communication behaviour in response to contextual cues and any pre-existing stereotypes (Zhang & Giles, 2018). As a result, when individuals interact with other groups, their perceptions of communication are influenced by the group to which they belong (Giles, 2005; Montgomery & Zhang, 2018; Ruble & Zhang, 2012). This shows that complexities exist when people interact, and hence, form or develop their identities. Moreover, in these interactions, individuals actively shape and adjust their behaviour based on their perception of group stereotypes (Chen et al., 2021; Giles & Giles, 2013). Likewise, a person's social identity can negatively affect their interactions (McLeish & Oxoby, 2011). This further highlights the complexity of identity dynamics as well as the interactivity of interpersonal communication in different social contexts (Baym, 2006; Nakamura, 2005).

Considering the media and identity, the impression of one cultural group on another is realised in many ways, and of these, the media is the most influential (Arima, 2003; Collins et al., 2009; Kian, 2008). For example Itakura (2004) found that email and television news are major sources of stereotypes, and these stereotypes are shared through both verbal and non-verbal cues (Epley & Kruger, 2005). Besides, another paper published by Peng (2010), which considered stereotypes held about American, Japanese, and Chinese students found that some responsibility for this rested with media communication. By analysing media portrayals and their effects, the brief communication revealed a direct correlation between media content and the

formation of stereotypes, consequently hindering intercultural communication (Peng, 2010).

When considering the above-proposed question, ‘How does media influence and shape identity?’, it is evident that the media has a key role in shaping and influencing identity. This also extends beyond the individual and impacts group identity and impressions of other groups. However, based on the above analysis of multi-level, individual, and group identity-building processes, it should be noted that this process is not static, but dynamic, and due to changes in time and situations, identity cognition is constantly evolving.

4 Hall Model and Media Shaping

When exploring the impact of media stereotypes, Hall’s (1980) encoding/decoding model can be used to explore audiences’ perspectives on media interpretation. Therefore, this section now combines Hall’s (1980) model with the role of the media in eliminating negative impressions. Likewise, it seeks to explore related fields of identity dynamics and intercultural communication.

Appel and Weber (2021) explain that many studies have considered how such vulnerable groups as women, immigrants, members of non-white ethnic and racial groups, and the elderly are portrayed in various media and formats, especially in terms of stereotypes. Over the years, some depictions of gender, race, and age have improved due to various affirmative action movements, however, inequality continues to exist (Grossberg, 2006). For example, women continue to be underrepresented in popular media when compared to their male counterparts (Collins, 2011). More specifically, women lack dominant roles in films, television news, prime-time television, and music videos (Desmond & Danilewicz, 2010; Sink & Mastro, 2017; Smith & Granados, 2009; Turner, 2011). Furthermore, when women do appear, they are usually placed in stereotypically feminine roles, such as being placed in the domestic sphere (Kay & Furnham, 2013). On the contrary, men are usually placed in leadership positions and exert power in the workplace (Lauzen & Dozier, 2004). Furthermore, stereotypes of African Americans, Latinos, and the elderly are frequently depicted in the media (Mastro, 2009; Mastro & Behm-Morawitz, 2005; Williams et al., 2009). These stereotypes have a negative impact on intercultural communication (Liu & Zhang, 2020; Peng, 2010), making it difficult to communicate before actually engaging in communication.

Returning to Hall’s (1980) model of encoding and decoding, this paper conducts a nuanced analysis to illuminate how each dimension of the model operates within the context of two selected news. The first news, sourced from *The Independent* in 2015, delves into public reactions to the revelation that Syrian refugees possess smartphones. Employing a biting and ironic tone, the essay seeks to challenge entrenched assumptions about refugee demographics, epitomised by the blunt assertion, “Sorry to break this to you, but you’re an idiot.” (*The Independent*, 2015). This provocative statement serves as a rhetorical device to disrupt prevailing stereotypes and prompt readers to critically reassess their perceptions of poverty and technological access within refugee communities (Kolmakova et al., 2022).

Applying Hall's model (1980) to this analysis, this paper observes the audience engaging in an 'oppositional reading' of the news content. Instead of passively accepting the media's portrayal of Syrian refugees as impoverished and technologically deprived, readers actively challenge this narrative, recognising the inherent biases and stereotypes perpetuated by mainstream discourse. By adopting an oppositional stance, the audience not only rejects the notion that refugee populations are inherently disadvantaged but also advocates for a more nuanced understanding of their lived experiences (Lau et al., 2024). Furthermore, Hall's model (1980) prompts us to consider the broader socio-political context within which media narratives are constructed and interpreted. In this case, the news serves as a microcosm of larger debates surrounding immigration, poverty, and social inclusion. By critically engaging with the media text through the lens of Hall's model, we can uncover the underlying power dynamics and ideological agendas that shape public discourse (Shaw, 2017).

Meanwhile, the second news is concerned with teachers being banned from the profession for such reasons as misgendering their students. There are three different versions of this story, and each commentary applies a contrasting title and focus (Clarence-Smith, 2023; Reuteurs Fact Check, 2023; Russell, 2023). Russell's (2023) report directly refers to teachers being banned because of students' "gender error", Clarence-Smith (2023) focuses on "gender discrimination, while Reuteurs Fact Check (2023) emphasises "banned for numerous reasons". This led to many different comments from the audience when they were exposed to the stories. According to Hall's (1980) model, the three versions can be unpicked in terms of how they are encoded and decoded, and it can also be determined how these different representations may affect readers' understanding and perception of the event. Firstly, both Russell's (2023) and Clarence-Smith's (2023) reports suggest a potential bias in the encoding process, as both writers might have shaped the information to align with their individual perspectives, values, or situational contexts (Fowler, 2013). Russell's (2023) report emphasised the so-called "gender error", potentially leading readers to interpret it as a simple mistake by the teacher and, consequently, view the verdict as unfair. Meanwhile, Clarence-Smith (2023) took a more gendered angle, potentially prompting some readers to adopt a 'dominant reading' and advocate for stricter punishment for the teacher. Later, however, Reuteurs Fact Check (2023) reported that the teacher had been banned from teaching for numerous reasons, and therefore, the audience could use 'negotiating reading' to analyse this news; that is, they could consider each of these reports dialectically from multiple angles.

It can be argued that Hall's (1980) model can challenge stereotypes and cultivate self-reflection (Meyers & Gayle, 2015). By considering the above news commentary, it is evident that the model can be used by the audience to discover any issues from an objective or multi-perspective of different reports or comments, as well as engage in critical thinking on this basis. This is conducive to eliminating the possible negative effects of the media and helps to promote more objective and ideal information acquisition and cognition.

When considering identity dynamics and media interactions, the audience is positioned in a constantly evolving environment with ample opportunities for interaction. As Appel and Weber (2021) explain, the media can shape audiences' perceptions of

different identities through its presentation of images, emphasis on certain points of view, or the portrayal of certain groups. For example, Grossberg (2006) explored the racist stereotypes of Black people in the last century and explained that they rarely appear on formal occasions or in the media. However, currently, the media has changed its portrayal of black people, something demonstrated in the casting of the new Disney film *The Little Mermaid* (Marshall, 2023), which featured a black female protagonist. Although this was met with some controversy over political correctness, this choice attempted to break the Hollywood white supremacy era (E. C. Scott, 2015). This also changed the concept of identity as the times changed and were redefined (K. D. Scott, 2013).

Finally, the formation of cultural stereotypes in intercultural communication is the result of the media, where specific reporting methods or content presentation forms can reinforce some preconceived stereotypes about other cultures. In a study conducted by Behm-Morawitz and Ortiz (2013), it was found that Latinos are under-represented on English-language television in the United States. Moreover, their commentary highlighted that Latino people are often stereotypically depicted as lovers or clowns. This similar portrayal often affects intercultural communication, however, audiences from diverse cultural backgrounds tend to interpret and comprehend media content differently based on their cultural experiences, shaping contrasting attitudes and viewpoints. In this way, the Hall model aids in understanding and depicting the diverse attitudes and identity images emerging among audiences from various cultures, thereby offering some assistance in mitigating negative portrayals perpetuated by the media (Xie et al., 2022).

As considered previously, the Hall (1980) model has some limitations. The model's assumption of an audience with unfiltered autonomy in media interpretation overlooks the intricate influences of social, cultural, and ethical facets. Nevertheless, this oversight might lead to deviations in information processing and perception. Eco (2003) particularly underscores that an audience is heavily influenced by social, cultural, and even ethical and religious positions. Hence, while the Hall model offers a valuable perspective, its idealistic premise necessitates a whole consideration of the multifaceted influences on audience understanding.

5 Conclusion

To conclude, Hall's (1980) model can provide a systematic framework to understand and recognise stereotyping and identity in media and intercultural communication; it also provides an initiative to deal with negative images and stereotypes. Even though this model has some limitations, it still has a key place in the field of communication applications, especially as it remains under continuous research and improvement (Chen, 2019). In this era of popular media, the narratives and images displayed on television or other forms of media have great power and can easily affect people's views of the world (Yousman, 2013). At this time, it is necessary to compare and accept information from the three audience perspectives (dominant, negotiated, and oppositional readings) considered in Hall's model so that evaluations consider multiple angles and directions as a means to prevent prejudice. Furthermore, as an inter-

cultural communicator, utilising the audience's active perspectives is key to avoiding stereotypes, and emphasising diverse and inclusive viewpoints encourages comprehensive understanding.

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